

Research Reports

The research report is a concrete proof of the study that was undertaken.

The significant role that a research report is as follows:

- 🎬 documents all steps from framing of research question to interpretation of results and study findings
- 🎬 details of how and why the steps were carried out, i.e. justification for choosing one technique over the other.
- 🎬 authenticates the quality of the work and establishes the strength of the findings
- 🎬 gives direction in terms of implication of results
- 🎬 serves as a framework for further research on same area

Types of Research Reports

Types of Research Reports	
Brief Reports	Detailed reports
• Working papers • Survey reports	• Technical reports • Business reports

Brief Reports

These kinds of reports are not formally structured and are generally short, usually about 4 -5 pages.

Working papers or basic reports are written for the purpose of recording the research process in terms of scope of study, framework of study, methodology used, results and findings. However, interpretation of findings, study background, and past literature is usually not included.

Survey reports: Might not have an academic orientation. The focus is to present in simple and easy to understand format that includes figures and tables.

Detailed reports

These are more formal and could be academic, technical or business reports.

🎬 **Technical reports:** These are major documents and would include all elements of the basic report, as well as the interpretations and conclusions. All sources of data, sampling plan, data collection instrument(s), data analysis outputs are formally and sequentially documented.

🎬 **Business reports:** These reports include conclusions as understood by the business manager. Focus is more on narrative form to facilitate decision making by using pictorially representation, bar charts and graphs. Tabular data might be attached in the appendix.

Structure of Research Report

Research report has a structured format, and follows a standardized process. It is divided into standard sections and sub-sections.

Detailed technical report contains all elements of research report.

Preliminary Section
Title Page
Letter of Authorization
Executive Summary
Acknowledgements
Table of Contents
Background Section
Problem Statement
Study Introduction and Background
Scope Objectives of the Study
Review of Literature
Methodology Section
Research Design
Sampling Design
Data Collection
Data Analysis
Findings Section
Results
Interpretation of Results
Conclusions Section
Conclusion Recommendations
Limitations of the Study
Appendices
Glossary of Terms
Bibliography

The sequencing may be reversed in the management report to suit the needs of the decision-maker.

Preliminary Section

This section mainly consists of identification information of the study. It has the following individual elements:

Title page: The title should be crisp and indicative of the nature of the project.

Letter of Transmittal: This is the letter that broadly refers to the purpose of study.

Letter of Authorization: Copy of the letter that authorised the study.

Executive summary: The summary of the entire report is presented in narrative form.

Acknowledgements: A small note acknowledging the contribution of all those who provided inputs for accomplishing the study.

Table of contents: List major sections and subsections of the study, list of tables, list of figures, graphs, exhibits (if any) and list of appendices with page numbers.

Main Report

This is the most significant and academically robust part of the report. It is divided into standard sections.

Background Section: It has following sub-sections, namely, Problem Statement, Introduction and Study Background, Scope and Objectives of Study, and Review of Literature

- **Problem Definition/ Statement:** This sub-section presents the formal definition of the research problem.
- **Study background:** Study background gives a description of the theoretical and contemporary data that led to research problem and guided the research.
- **Study scope and objectives:** it presents statements related to the purpose of the study and the formulated hypotheses.
- In case of academic research, there is a separate section devoted to the review of related literature, which presents a detailed reporting of work done on the same or related topic of interest.

Methodology of Research: The section would essentially have five to six sub-sections specifying the details of how the research was conducted. These would essentially be:

- **Research framework or design:** The variables and concepts being investigated are clearly defined, with a clear reference to the relationship being studied. The justification for using a particular design also has to be presented here.
- **Sampling design:** The entire sampling plan in terms of the population being studied, along with the reasons for collecting the study-related information from the given group is given here.
- **Data collection methods:** Lists the information needed for the study as drawn from the study objectives stated earlier. The secondary data sources considered and the primary instrument designed for the specific study are discussed here.
- **Data analysis:** The assumptions and constraints of the analysis are explained here in simple, non-technical terms.

Study results and findings: This is the most critical chapter of the report.

Results: Presents the collected data and its analysis. This section often includes tables, graphs, and descriptive statistics to illustrate the findings.

Interpretation of Results: linking analysis of data to the research questions and existing literature.

Conclusion: Summarizes the key findings and their implications, Limitations of the study and may suggest areas for future research.

Appendices: May consist of two kinds of information.

1. **Secondary information:** Technical information in form of article that needs to be understood by the reader; long tables, legal or policy documents.

2. Primary data that cannot be compressed and presented in the main body of the report. This includes original questionnaire, formula used for the study, Computer programs used in study, long tables and graphs which can be described in statement form in the text.

Bibliography: Lists the papers cited in a standardized format. Lists may be presented in order of occurrence in text or in alphabetical order based on last name of author.

Glossary of Terms: In case there are specific terms and technical jargon used in the report, it is put in a glossary. This section is usually the last section of the report.

Research Proposal

Research proposal is similar to research report. Typical outline of Research proposal is as under.

Here's a general outline you might consider following:

1. **Title Page:** Includes research title, name of researcher(s), and their institutional affiliation.
2. **Abstract:** Contains a brief summary of research proposal, including the research question, objectives, methodology, and potential significance.
3. **Introduction:**
 - **Background:** Contextualize the research problem.
 - **Problem Statement:** States the problem that research will address.
 - **Research Questions:** Lists the primary and any secondary questions that the proposed research aims to answer.
 - **Objectives:** Defines the aims of proposed research.
4. **Literature Review:** Contains the summary of existing research related to research topic. Identify gaps that the research will fill.
5. **Research Methodology:**
 - **Research Design:** Explains the overall approach (e.g., qualitative, quantitative, mixed methods) that will be used.
 - **Data Collection:** Describes how and what data will be collected.
 - **Data Analysis:** Explain how the data will be analysed.
 - **Ethical Considerations:** Address ethical issues related to proposed research if any.
6. **Timeline:** Provide a detailed schedule of research activities. This is an important section of research proposal. It stipulates how the progress in research is evaluated.
7. **Budget:** Estimate the costs associated with research and justify the budget.
8. **References:** List all the sources cited in research proposal.
9. **Appendices** (if applicable): Include any additional materials, such as survey instruments, interview guides, etc.